

Cat

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This article is about the species commonly kept as a pet. For the cat family, see [Felidae](#). For other uses, see [Cat \(disambiguation\)](#) and [Cats \(disambiguation\)](#).

The **cat** (*Felis catus*) is a **domestic species** of small **carnivorous mammal**.^{[1][2]} It is the only domesticated species in the family **Felidae** and is commonly referred to as the **domestic cat** or **house cat** to distinguish it from the wild members of the family.^[4] Cats are commonly kept as house pets but can also be **farm cats** or **feral cats**; the feral cat ranges freely and avoids human contact.^[5] Domestic cats are valued by humans for companionship and their ability to kill **vermin**. About 60 **cat breeds** are recognized by various **cat registries**.^[6]

The cat is similar in **anatomy** to the other feline species: it has a strong flexible body, quick **reflexes**, sharp teeth, and **retractable claws** adapted to killing small prey like mice and rats. Its **night vision** and sense of smell are well developed. **Cat communication** includes vocalizations like **meowing**, **purring**, trilling, hissing, **growling**, and grunting as well as **cat-specific body language**. Although the cat is a **social species**, it is a solitary hunter. As a **predator**, it is **crepuscular**, i.e. most active at dawn and dusk. It can hear sounds too faint or too high in **frequency** for human ears, such as those made by **mice** and other small mammals.^[7] It also secretes and perceives **pheromones**.^[8]

Female domestic cats can have kittens from spring to late autumn, with litter sizes often ranging from two to five kittens.^[9] Domestic cats are bred and shown at events as registered **pedigreed cats**, a hobby known as **cat fancy**. **Population control** of cats may be achieved by **sparing** and **neutering**, but their proliferation and the abandonment of pets has resulted in large numbers of feral cats worldwide, contributing to the extinction of entire bird, mammal,

